Expressing wish, regret and obligation

Goal: To express wishes about the present and regrets about the past with **I wish / If only**, and to express obligation and absence of obligation with the right modals.

The idea in two lines: After *wish* we go one tense back: past for present wishes, past perfect for past regrets. Obligation uses *must, have to, should*, and past obligation uses *had to*.

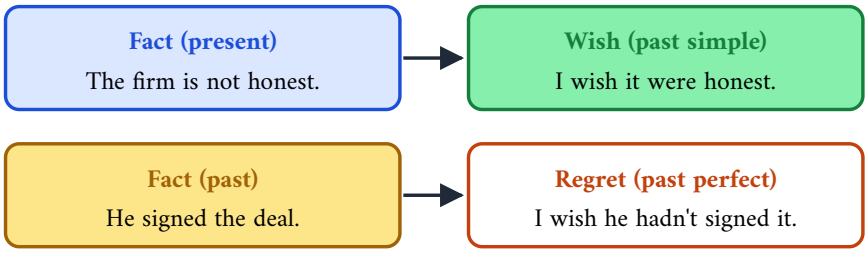


Figure 1: A wish goes one tense back and reverses the fact.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Present wish:** I wish / If only + past simple; use *were* for all persons.
2. **Past regret:** I wish / If only + past perfect: *I wish I had studied business ethics.*
3. **Wish + would:** annoyance or desire for change in someone else: *I wish they would stop polluting.*
4. **Should have + V3** also expresses regret or criticism: *They should have told the truth.*
5. **Obligation:** *must* (strong, internal or rules), *have to* (external), *should / ought to* (moral duty, advice); past: *had to*.
6. **No obligation:** *don't have to / needn't*; **prohibition:** *mustn't*.

🟢 Examples

1. Rewrite: *I'm sorry I didn't report the fraud.* **Solution:** I wish I **had reported** the fraud.

2. Rewrite: *Workers don't have good salaries.* **Solution:** If only workers **had** good salaries.
3. Choose: *Employees (mustn't / don't have to) accept bribes.* **Solution:** mustn't. **Explanation:** it is forbidden, not just unnecessary.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Keeping the same tense after *wish*: *I wish I am rich* is wrong.
- Forgetting to reverse the meaning: a negative fact becomes a positive wish.
- Confusing *mustn't* (forbidden) with *don't have to* (not necessary).
- Writing *musted*; the past of *must* is *had to*.

🟡 Quick review

- Wish (now) = past simple / were.
- Regret (past) = had + V3, or should have + V3.
- Must / have to = obligation; had to = past obligation.
- Mustn't = forbidden; don't have to = not necessary.

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